

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1989-07-10

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

1 dear bahá'í friends,

The holy word has been extolled by the prophets of god as the medium

2 of celestial power and the wellspring of all spiritual, social and material progress. Access to it, constant study of it and daily use of it in our individual lives are vital to the inner personal transformation towards which we strive and whose ultimate outer manifestation will be the emergence of that

3 divine civilization which is the promise of the world order of bahá'u'lláh.

The blessings which flow from the word of god are implicit in this

4 instruction of bahá'u'lláh in the kitáb-i-Aqdas, the mother book of his
5 revelation: "immerse yourselves in the ocean of my words, that ye may
6 unravel its secrets, and discover all the pearls of wisdom that lie hid in its
7 depths." Again in the same book, he bids us recite the "verses of god every

morning and evening."

8 68-1 An astonishing insight as to the sublime influence
9 of the revealed word is conveyed in this further instruction gleaned from
10 one of his Tablets: "intone, O my servant, the verses of god that have
11 been received by thee, as intoned by them who have drawn nigh unto him,
12 that the sweetness of thy melody may kindle thine own soul, and attract the hearts of
all men. whoso reciteth, in the privacy of his chamber, the verses

13 revealed by god, the scattering angels of the Almighty shall scatter abroad
14 the fragrance of the words uttered by his mouth, and shall cause the heart of every
righteous man to throb. Though he may, at first, remain unaware of

15 68-1. revised translation in the kitáb-i-Aqdas: "recite ye the verses of god every

morn and eventide." (¶149)68.1

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69 1986-1992 • The Six Year Plan

70 11its effect, yet the virtue of the grace vouchsafed unto him must needs sooner
or later exercise its influence upon his soul.”68-2

The most immediate access to the dynamic influence of the sacred word

71 is through reading. The ability to read is therefore a fundamental right and
72 privilege of every human being. bahá’u’lláh promotes this right in his com-
73 mand to parents to ensure the instruction of their sons and daughters in the
74 “art of reading and writing.”68-3 for this essential reason, in our last riḡvân
75 message we called attention to the need for systematic attention to be given
76 to eventually eliminating illiteracy from the bahá’í community. This mat-
77 ter must assume its proper importance as a continuing objective of that
78 community.
79 let each National and local Spiritual Assembly, according to necessity
80 and circumstance, address itself to this objective, conscious that even where
81 total achievement is not immediately possible, opportunities must be sought to make
steady progress. let each be confident that the shining example set
82 by iran, the mother community of the bahá’í world, under the inspiration
83 of bahá’u’lláh’s teachings and the urging of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá and Shoghi ef-
84 fendi, upholds a standard all can follow. in the earliest years of this century,
85 when no systematic, overall plan of education existed in iran, the bahá’ís
86 seized their chance and organized a widespread program of education. its
87 teachers were distinguished for their ability to foster child, youth and adult
education, which led to significant self-improvement among the iranian
88 bahá’ís. The emergence of a literate bahá’í community was an outstanding
89 result.

Some local or national bahá’í communities may wish to follow the ex-

90 ample of those who have already instituted their own literacy projects and are
achieving notable success; others may wish to participate in literacy pro-
91 grams organized by governmental or nongovernmental organizations. each
92 community will have to determine whether to engage in one or the other, or
93 to do both. progress will depend not only on the initiatives of bahá’í institu-
94 tions in relation to children, but also on the active interest of adult believers who
want to learn to read. Such friends should definitely be encouraged and assisted to achieve,

with dignity, their heart's desire. certainly, the willing

95 participation of the friends in an undertaking of such importance to the

96 68-2. kA, ¶182, 149; gwb, no. 136.2.

97 68-3. kA, ¶48.68.3

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69 m e S S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

70 12upliftment of individuals and the consolidation of the bahá'í community as

71 a whole will attract divine favors and confirmations.

72 The united Nations has declared 1990 to be international literacy year

73 so as to mobilize an all-out, ongoing effort to eradicate illiteracy around the

74 world. The literacy projects already in progress in the bahá'í community,

75 and those which are yet to be adopted, will surely lend support to this noble

76 and necessary effort. Therefore, we commend the purpose of this special

77 year to the attention of the entire bahá'í world. The bahá'í international

78 community's united Nations office will send National Assemblies infor-

79 mation concerning activities associated with international literacy year and

how bahá'í communities may become involved. moreover, agencies at the

80 bahá'í world center having a special interest in literacy programs will offer

81 helpful advice as necessary, but Spiritual Assemblies need not wait to hear

82 from them before proceeding with their own plans.

we look forward with confident expectation to your achievements to-

83 ward the ultimate fulfillment of this objective which is so essential to the

84 progress of the bahá'í community and indeed all humanity. And we assure

85 you, as ever, of our continuing prayers at the holy Shrines for your success.

86 with loving bahá'í greetings,

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The Role of the Nineteen Day Feast

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]